

Chapter 73_1 - Jealous

Chu Qingqiu immediately spotted Ning Fuyi in Jiuying's arms and hurried forward several steps, her skirt's ripples becoming disheveled, raising her hand to feel Ning Fuyi's forehead.

Jiuying, who had been quite solemn, saw Chu Qingqiu present and the anxiety on her face instantly faded, transforming into a smile with dimples. She nimbly retreated a step, holding Ning Fuyi to avoid Chu Qingqiu's hand.

Chu Qingqiu's hand touched empty air, and only then did she shift her gaze to Jiuying's action of tightly embracing Ning Fuyi. She secretly clenched her fists, her peach blossom eyes lifting slightly: "Let go."

"Why is the Divine Venerable so anxious? This little girl suddenly fainted, and I was just about to take her to find a medical immortal." Jiuying pursed her lips in a light smile, lifting Ning Fuyi higher in her arms so that the face flushed red from pain rested against her chest.

This sight nearly made the white bone in Chu Qingqiu's hand transform directly into a white jade staff. She sheathed the white bone with her other hand and extended her soft, pale palm toward Jiuying: "Medical immortals cannot cure her ailment. If you delay further, do you want her to die!"

"Such a wonderful person as the Divine Venerable, how can your temper be worse than mine? I have formed a contract with her now, so only I know her physical condition best. Her life is much longer than yours - you're not even worried about your own life, so why are you anxious about hers now?" Jiuying's narrow phoenix eyes swept over Chu Qingqiu's entire body.

Chu Qingqiu finally could bear no more and directly turned her palm to summon immortal power, striking Jiuying with a palm that forced her to retreat. Then she withdrew her palm, and Ning Fuyi was lifted into the air by a Flying Feather Rope¹ wrapped around her waist, her dress gracefully flowing as she landed steadily in Chu Qingqiu's arms.

That fair face with a rosy flush pressed against her chest, and she could feel the burning heat even through her clothes.

She did not delay, carrying clouds as she soared into the air, disappearing behind the palace walls in the blink of an eye.

Jiuying covered her chest where she had been struck with her hand, but did not retaliate. Her brows were initially furrowed, then she slowly straightened her waist, her lips curving in a smile as she watched the direction the two had departed.

Then, from nowhere, she produced a fan made of blue feathers, fanning herself leisurely as she walked toward Jingshan Palace².

Meanwhile, Chu Qingqiu had already landed at the door with Ning Fuyi in her arms, startling Qiuyi who was waiting at the entrance. Her eyes swept over Ning Fuyi in Chu Qingqiu's embrace, her eyes widening in shock. She wanted to say something but was interrupted by Chu Qingqiu.

"Where is Medical Immortal Jiang?" Chu Qingqiu asked urgently.

Qiuyi gestured with her hand: "The medical immortal has already gone in. What happened to her..."

Chu Qingqiu had no time to answer, sidestepping around Qiuyi, her body transforming into points of light as she paused twice on the steps before pushing the door open and entering.

Jiang Li, who was methodically organizing her medicine box, turned her head, her refined features showing surprise, then rose to her feet, watching as Chu Qingqiu carried the person to the bed and carefully laid her down.

"Your little disciple only said you urgently requested me, but couldn't explain why, making me think the Divine Venerable's old injuries had relapsed. I dropped urgent matters and rushed here overnight." Jiang Li stood and walked to the bedside. "So it turns out the injured person is not the Divine Venerable."

"My apologies. Last night in my urgency, I failed to explain clearly to the medical immortal. It was my oversight." Chu Qingqiu pulled the quilt over Ning Fuyi, her eyes full of undisguised worry.

"Since returning from the tiger's den, she complained of headaches. Last night I suppressed her six senses³ to provide relief, but who knew she would suffer another attack today, actually fainting from the pain. I trouble the medical immortal to examine her and see what exactly is wrong." Chu Qingqiu said in a low voice.

Jiang Li gave Chu Qingqiu a thoughtful look, then looked at Ning Fuyi, before forming hand seals with both hands, manifesting several silver threads in mid-air that connected end to end to form an array.

She then closed her eyes and softly recited an incantation. The array burst with light, transforming into hundreds of silver threads that penetrated Ning Fuyi's body. Ning Fuyi immediately bit down hard, breaking out in cold sweat from the pain.

Unconsciously, she raised her hand and grabbed Chu Qingqiu's sleeve, gripping so tightly that blue veins appeared on her pale hand.

Seeing this, Chu Qingqiu felt her own head begin to ache. She did not withdraw her sleeve but let Ning Fuyi hold onto it.

As fine sweat accumulated more and more on Ning Fuyi's forehead, Jiang Li's own forehead grew moist, her steps becoming unsteady as if she had encountered great trouble.

"Divine Venerable, her sea of consciousness is sealed - I cannot enter!" Jiang Li said word by word, using all her strength to control those silver threads. "I can only use the secret technique of the Jiang family. Please assist me, Divine Venerable!"

Seeing this, Chu Qingqiu said nothing more, flicking her long sleeves to summon immortal power, continuously channeling it into Jiang Li's body. Only then did Jiang Li stabilize her form.

Her hands quickly drew another array in mid-air, then another orange-yellow light emerged from her brow and surged into the array.

Then Jiang Li closed her eyes, leaving only the light from her brow.

A full incense stick's worth of time passed, long enough that Chu Qingqiu's immortal power was nearly depleted, before Jiang Li finally ceased her technique. Her hands circled once, withdrawing the array, and the room's light returned to normal.

Jiang Li exhaled a long breath, using her shawl to wipe the sweat from her forehead, then took Ning Fuyi's pulse, her expression complex.

"What happened to her?" Chu Qingqiu asked.

Jiang Li hesitated, then shook her head: "I have temporarily stopped her pain. She should be sleeping now. Divine Venerable, may I speak with you privately?"

She looked toward the door as she spoke. Chu Qingqiu understood her meaning and called out toward the window: "Qiuyi, go guard the entrance to Jingshan Palace. Without my command, no one is permitted to enter."

Qiuyi acknowledged and her footsteps pattered away.

Seeing no one else around, Jiang Li finally spoke seriously: "Does the Divine Venerable know what is in her sea of consciousness?"

"Those two trees." Chu Qingqiu said softly, her gaze passing through the screen to look distantly at the unconscious Ning Fuyi, her heartstrings growing increasingly taut.

"So the Divine Venerable knows. Did she tell you?" Jiang Li showed some surprise. "It seems the young sect master greatly trusts the Divine Venerable, willing to speak of such important matters."

"A person's sea of consciousness is where the soul resides. It's not surprising for souls to contain various things." Chu Qingqiu lowered her gaze.

"I cannot see through those two trees either, only knowing their power is too strong, and they are incompatible like fire and water. I just used the Jiang family secret technique 'Spirit Sea Plum Exploration' to forcibly enter her sea of consciousness, but could only see dimly for a moment." Jiang Li's smile faded. "The tree with black fruit seems to have suffered some impact. The fruit has rotted, and its power is faintly merging into her sea of consciousness."

"What kind of power?" Chu Qingqiu frowned.

"It seems like demonic energy." Jiang Li steadied herself before speaking.

"Demonic energy? How could that be? I clearly..." Chu Qingqiu nearly lost her composure, reaching out to grip the edge of the bookshelf, clenching it tightly to regain her reason.

Seeing her state, Jiang Li quickly reached out: "Divine Venerable, don't be anxious. I only glimpsed it for a moment - perhaps I was mistaken. It might not be demonic energy but something else."

"What's important is that this tree is the source of the young sect master's headaches. Its power is forcibly merging with the young sect master's soul, attempting to occupy her sea of consciousness." Jiang Li said quickly. "That's why the young sect master suffers such unbearable pain."

"But the other tree - I couldn't determine anything about it. Its power is gentle and soft, yet equally immensely powerful. I..."

"It's fine." Chu Qingqiu interrupted her words, saying quietly, "I know what it is."

Jiang Li was startled, then smiled slightly: "If the Divine Venerable knows, that's good. I have the professional discretion of a physician and won't ask more."

"However, how to resolve the young sect master's headaches still requires careful study. I've practiced medicine for a hundred years and cured all manner of difficult ailments, but the young sect master's condition is truly challenging. Please give me two more days, Divine Venerable." Jiang Li said.

"Naturally I won't make things difficult for the medical immortal." Chu Qingqiu's emotions settled as she released her grip, saying softly, "Only I hope the medical immortal will keep what you just told me strictly confidential."

"That's natural. I've traveled everywhere practicing medicine and heard countless secrets, yet have never let any slip." Jiang Li's eyes sparkled.

She suddenly remembered something and pressed the standing Chu Qingqiu down onto the sitting platform, silver threads emerging from her fingertips again: "After treating the Divine Venerable's condition last time, I haven't had a follow-up examination. Now is the perfect opportunity."

Before Chu Qingqiu could stop her, the silver threads had already entered her heart. She hastily said it wasn't necessary and swept her palm to sever the silver threads.

However, it was still a step too late. Jiang Li's previously smiling face suddenly changed color. She retreated two steps, withdrawing her immortal power, staring at Chu Qingqiu in shock.

Chu Qingqiu felt momentarily guilty, her picturesque brows turning away from the sunlit side toward the shadows.

"Divine Venerable." Jiang Li withdrew her hands into her sleeves. "Before I left, I told the Divine Venerable that you already had injuries and your body was deteriorating. If you continued to forcibly overdraw your immortal power, then..."

"How long do I have left to live?" Chu Qingqiu didn't let her continue but asked softly.

Jiang Li took a deep breath, suppressing the heaviness in her heart, then shook her head: "At most one year."

One year...

That would be enough time. Chu Qingqiu looked at her palm, where faint feather-shaped fluorescence flickered.

"But this is only at most. If the Divine Venerable continues to forcibly use immortal power and overdraw your body like this, how short your lifespan might be compressed, I cannot say." Jiang Li sighed deeply.

Chu Qingqiu nodded and actually smiled: "Thank you."

Jiang Li's words were blocked in her mouth by this smile. She lowered her head and tugged at her shawl several times before turning back to examine Ning Fuyi.

"I, Jiang Li, truly owe the Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate⁴. The big and small ones, living and dead, none give me peace." Jiang Li muttered quietly, then checked Ning Fuyi's pulse again.

Ning Fuyi coughed several times and finally opened her eyes. The aftereffects of the headache dissipated, leaving behind a heavy feeling throughout her mind. Her eyes blinked wearily, then realizing where she was, she suddenly sat up.

"Lie down." Jiang Li at the bedside said, holding several silver needles.

Ning Fuyi glanced at her, then looked toward Chu Qingqiu: "Divine Venerable..."

"If you don't lie down, these silver needles might pierce the wrong place and hit your vital points - don't blame me then." Jiang Li said with lowered eyelids.

Not knowing what had happened, Ning Fuyi looked at Chu Qingqiu once, then slowly lay down.

The moment she lay down, several silver needles pierced her acupoints. Ning Fuyi closed her eyes as her whole body became numb and tingling, as if streams of power were flowing through the needles into her entire body.

"Medical Immortal Jiang, what's wrong with me?" Ning Fuyi asked. Her memory still stopped at the moment when the headache suddenly struck.

Before Jiang Li could speak, Chu Qingqiu at her side spoke first, stepping to the bedside: "It's nothing serious, just soul damage from the tiger's den that left lingering effects."

Lingering effects? Ning Fuyi's eyes moved. What kind of lingering effects would cause such piercing, bone-deep pain?

Jiang Li looked at Chu Qingqiu, then at Ning Fuyi, not exposing her, only withdrawing her hands and saying indifferently: "These silver needles need to remain for half an hour to temporarily suppress the pain. Rest here for now."

After speaking, she bowed to Chu Qingqiu: "Divine Venerable, shall we go outside so as not to disturb her?"

Chu Qingqiu nodded, and the two walked out the door, their figures one after another descending the pavilion, only to encounter Jiuying walking into the courtyard with her hands behind her back.

Footnotes:

¹ Flying Feather Rope (飞羽索) - A magical rope-like weapon/tool used by cultivators

² Jingshan Palace (静山宫) - "Quiet Mountain Palace," Chu Qingqiu's residence

³ Six senses (六识) - In Buddhist/Daoist philosophy: sight, hearing, smell, taste, touch, and mind consciousness

⁴ Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate (云际山门) - The sect's name